whisper house

A score for four guests and one empty house.

What is whisper house?

whisper house is a score for four performers, called Guests, in an empty house. Their quiet domestic actions form a household vigil around someone or something left unspecified. The score can be read as a visual-musical text, performed, or encountered through an audio or video recording.

Sound composition

The Guests' actions produce sounds heard across rooms and through doors. Distance and the house's layout shape what is heard. An audio recording can be a form of the work.

Literature

The score can be read and looked at without being performed. Its notation and surreal instructions can be approached as experimental poetry or speculative fiction.

Fictional document

The score can be read as a document from an imagined world.

Ritual

Reading or performing the score can be treated as a ritual organized around repeated acts of attention and care.

Performance art

The work consists of the Guests' actions within the house. A video recording can present those actions as a form of the work.

Theater

Actors can portray the Guests in an extended scene structured by the score.

Conceptual art

The actions can be imagined, including those that are impossible to carry out. This mental enactment can itself constitute the work.

> *Some instructions describe surreal, impossible, or invisible actions. Performers may omit these actions, enact them symbolically, or imagine the feelings and gestures they suggest.*

Performance notes

The four performers are designated **Guests 1–4** in the score.

- Guest 4 acts only at the end.
- Guest 1 begins with a phone or laptop.
- Guest 3 begins with an encyclopedia.
- Unspecified details are left to the performers' interpretation.

Location: A performance requires a house with at least one room that has a door and a doorknob.

Materials

Books and paper

- Encyclopedia (Guest 3)
- Dictionary and novel
- Envelope

Kitchen and dining

- Frying pan and egg
- Pitcher, water, glasses, and plates
- Cutlery (forks, spoons, and knives)
- Vegetables and spices

Household and personal items

- Phone or laptop (Guest 1), and landline phone
- Radio and electric fan
- Laundry basket, basin, and clothes
- Broom, shell, and medicine or pills
- Tsinelas (slippers) and toothbrush

Audience

The performers may be their own audience. Other listeners or viewers may be anywhere in the house, separate from the performers, or encounter the work through a video recording.

Program notes

CONCEPT

In whisper house, people continue their household activities while repeatedly checking on someone or something fragile. They move quietly to avoid disturbing whoever or whatever is being cared for.

I draw this situation from four experiences of care in my family: the deaths of our cats, my childhood illnesses, my grandfather's illness, and my younger siblings' infancy.

Our cats. Four of my family's cats had feline immunodeficiency virus. Their health declined over months or years, with periods of recovery that made it difficult to decide when to call for euthanasia. In each cat's final weeks, my family of four kept the cat in one room to monitor changes and took turns looking in. I did not want to disturb an animal that was already suffering. Checking one at a time seemed less overwhelming for the cat. At night, my family hoped the cat could hold on until the vet could make a house call in the morning, avoiding the distress of transport. The four cats died roughly a year apart during the pandemic.

Childhood illness. When I was sick as a child, people came in and out of my room, speaking softly and attending to me while keeping the household running. Lying in bed with a fever, I heard ironing, food frying, doors and

windows opening and closing, and footsteps elsewhere in the house. These sounds connected me to activities I could not see. I later wondered whether my cats heard the household in a similar way while they were dying.

My grandfather. When I was young, my grandfather had cardiovascular problems and strokes that required repeated hospital stays. At home, house helpers, my parents, or my aunt slept in his room to respond if something happened at night. Someone also stayed with him in the hospital. I visited at least once a week for two years until he died. Sometimes I sat with him in the hospital room without speaking.

My younger siblings. My siblings are much younger than I am. When they were infants, they slept in a cradle in a quiet room. During their afternoon naps, members of the household took turns looking in on them while continuing their chores. I entered quietly to retrieve something or to check on them. The need to attend without disturbing them recalled the vigils around illness and dying.

> *I leave the fragile presence unspecified so that the vigil can be read through any of these experiences of care.*

The soundscape can be approached from the position of the fragile presence or from that of a caretaker. During these vigils, I looked for small activities that gave me something to do without demanding my full attention. They helped me avoid dwelling on the situation while remaining ready to respond. The Guests' household activities follow this pattern of keeping occupied while attending to something else.

Open questions

The score leaves the identities of the Guests, the house, and the presence receiving care open to interpretation.

- Who is the audience?
- What is the house?
- Who or what is being cared for?
- What is fragile here?
- Why are the Guests "guests"?
- How many characters are in this piece?
- What is being performed?
- Where is this taking place?

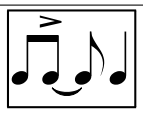
whisper house

for four guests and one empty house

come il tempo è un oceano

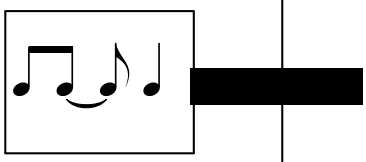
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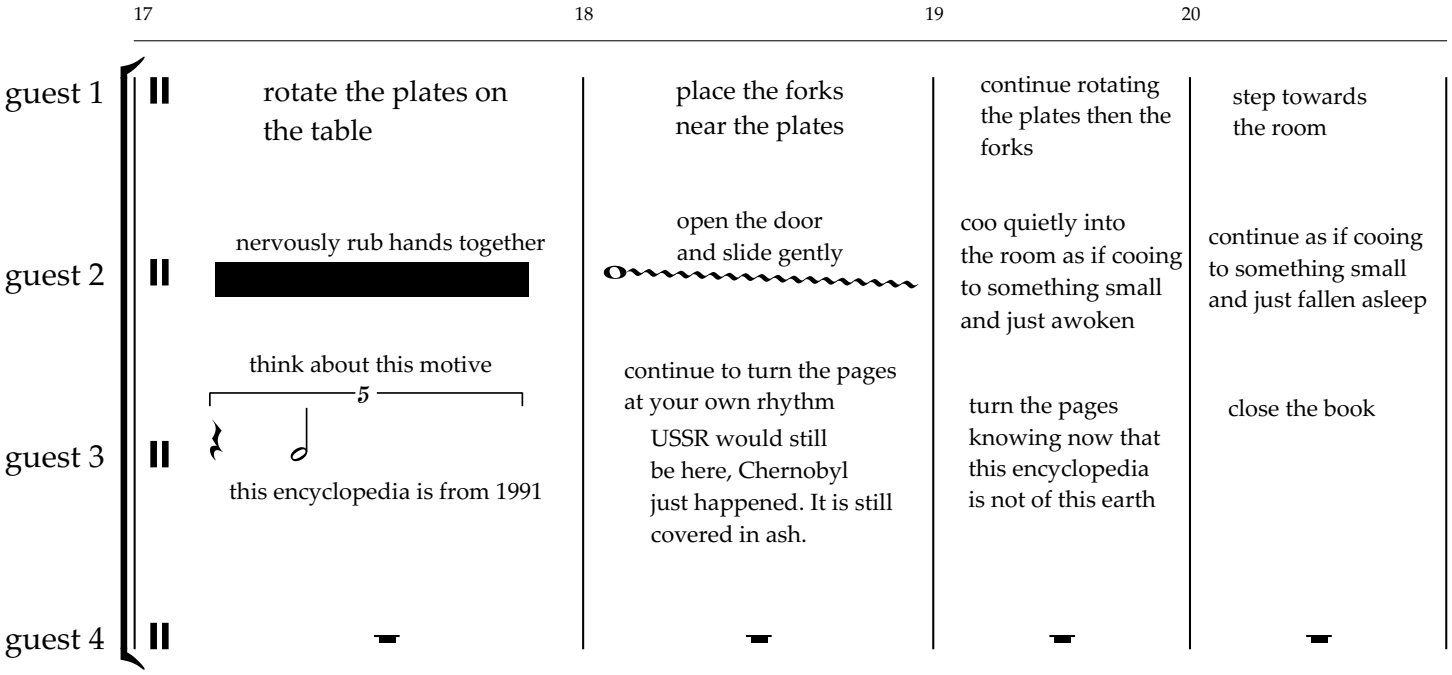
each measure lasts around 30 seconds each

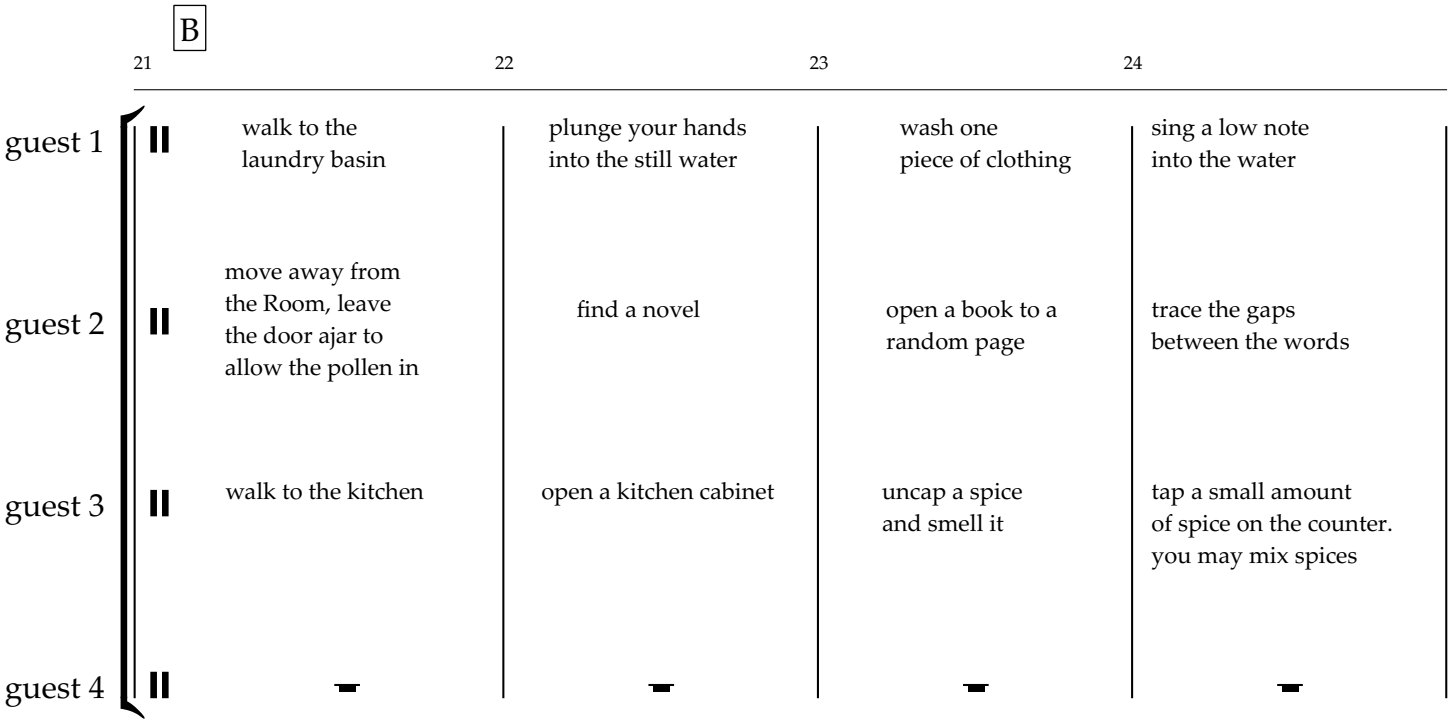
	1	2	3	4
guest 1	30 sec *p* whisper to each other	 walk quietly towards a window, to the door, and back to the window	stare at the door of the room	tap on the window while staring at the door
guest 2	30 sec *p* whisper to each other	whisper to each other	 walk towards the bathroom	turn on the faucet slightly, turn it off, then on
guest 3	30 sec *p* whisper to each other	whisper to each other	whisper to yourself	go to the radio and turn it on at a low volume
guest 4	30 sec	-	-	-

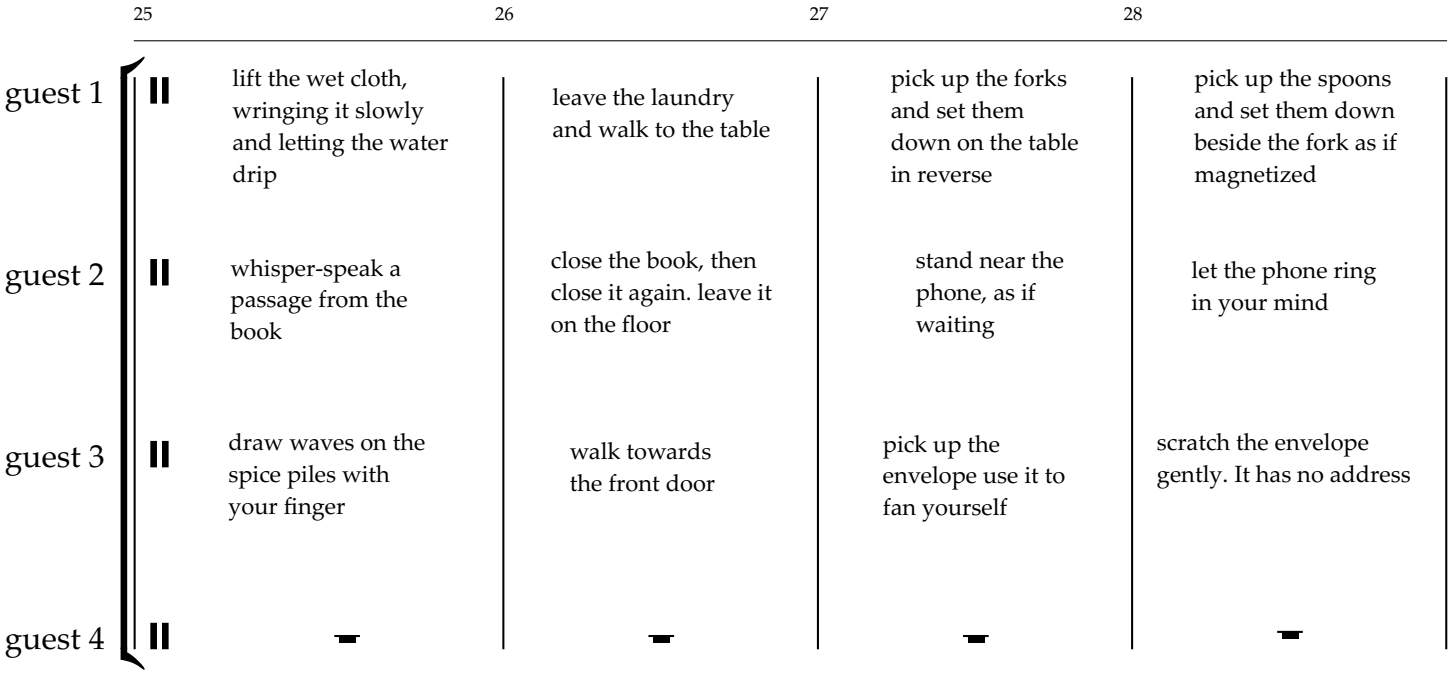
	5	6	7	8
guest 1	take deep breaths and sway	 walk towards the kitchen	open the drawers with cutlery	assemble the vegetables for chopping at the table. As if you are not sure which is first and last
guest 2	run your hands through the water then turn off the faucet	tap on the mirror while staring at the door	take deep breaths, and sway. Blow on the wind	Gather clothes and put them in the laundry basket
guest 3	listen to the radio, and be unsure about what it says	Clap softly to yourself	walk in a circle around the room, slowly	stare outside the window
guest 4	-	-	-	-

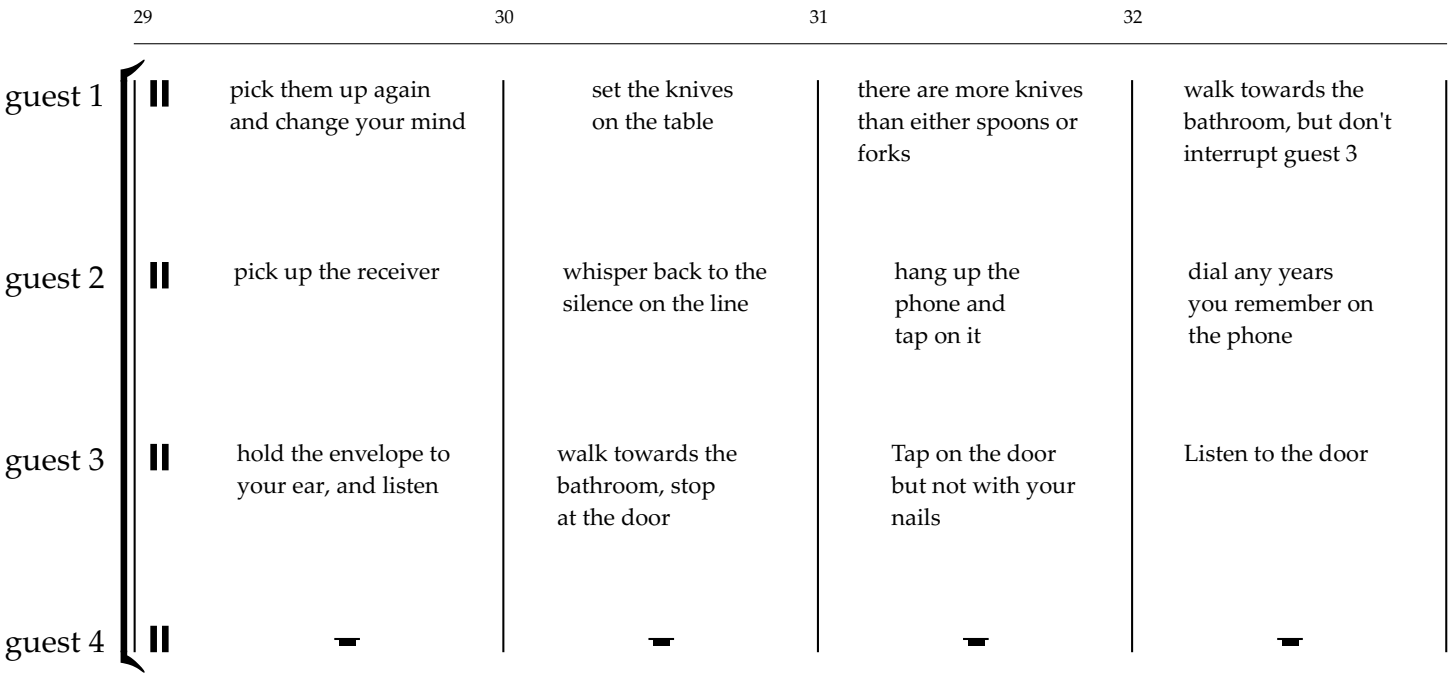
	9	10	11	12
guest 1	fill the pitcher with water, if it is empty	turn on the electric fan listen to its wind	move through the settings of the electric fan. Leave it on	find the encyclopedia and place it on the floor
guest 2	hum a tune	clap softly to yourself	walk towards the ktichen	stare at the vegetables
guest 3	stare outside the window	go to the laundry basket, and hold the clothes in your arms	dance with the clothes in your arms, softly humming, put them in the laundry basin	fill the laundry basin with water
guest 4				

	13	14	15	16
guest 1	connect to the wi-fi	realize you don't know the password. It is not in the encyclopedia	arrange the tsinelas near the entrance	walk towards the table
guest 2	pour some water, slowly	take small sips of water	place glasses on the table	 walk towards the room
guest 3	walk to the kitchen and select plates	place the plates on the tables	watch the glasses being placed on the table and move towards the encyclopedia	turn the pages of the encyclopedia *ppp*
guest 4				

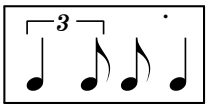
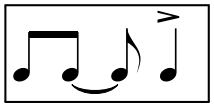

17
18
19
20
guest 1
guest 2
guest 3
guest 4
rotate the plates on the table
nervously rub hands together
think about this motive
5
this encyclopedia is from 1991
place the forks near the plates
open the door and slide gently
continue to turn the pages at your own rhythm
USSR would still be here, Chernobyl just happened. It is still covered in ash.
continue rotating the plates then the forks
coo quietly into the room as if cooing to something small and just awoken
turn the pages knowing now that this encyclopedia is not of this earth
step towards the room
continue as if cooing to something small and just fallen asleep
close the book

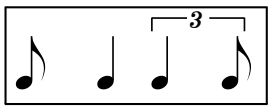

B
21
22
23
24
guest 1
guest 2
guest 3
guest 4
walk to the laundry basin
move away from the Room, leave the door ajar to allow the pollen in
walk to the kitchen
plunge your hands into the still water
find a novel
open a kitchen cabinet
wash one piece of clothing
open a book to a random page
uncap a spice and smell it
sing a low note into the water
trace the gaps between the words
tap a small amount of spice on the counter. you may mix spices


25
26
27
28
guest 1
lift the wet cloth, wringing it slowly and letting the water drip
leave the laundry and walk to the table
pick up the forks and set them down on the table in reverse
pick up the spoons and set them down beside the fork as if magnetized
guest 2
whisper-speak a passage from the book
close the book, then close it again. leave it on the floor
stand near the phone, as if waiting
let the phone ring in your mind
guest 3
draw waves on the spice piles with your finger
walk towards the front door
pick up the envelope use it to fan yourself
scratch the envelope gently. It has no address
guest 4


29
30
31
32
guest 1
pick them up again and change your mind
set the knives on the table
there are more knives than either spoons or forks
walk towards the bathroom, but don't interrupt guest 3
guest 2
pick up the receiver
whisper back to the silence on the line
hang up the phone and tap on it
dial any years you remember on the phone
guest 3
hold the envelope to your ear, and listen
walk towards the bathroom, stop at the door
Tap on the door but not with your nails
Listen to the door
guest 4

each measure from here lasts around 15 seconds each

	33	34	35	36
guest 1	stand in front of the bathroom sink and let the faucet trickle	stand in front of the bathroom sink and let the faucet trickle	15 sec	
guest 2	sit at the table and try to perceive guest 1 and guest 3	tap on the table	15 sec  tap repeatedly 2-3 times then freely improvise	
guest 3	walk away from the bathroom and stand in the middle of any room of your choice	walk away from the bathroom and stand in the middle of any room of your choice	15 sec	 stomp and clap repeatedly 2-3 times then freely improvise
guest 4			15 sec	

	37	38	39	40
guest 1	 splash repeatedly 2-3 times then freely improvise	splash the water in the rhythm of the phrase "house without wheels" repeatedly		tap on the table what guest 1 and guest 3 have played repeatedly, without concerning yourself of your own memory or what you've heard
guest 2		listen to guest 1	listen to guest 3	
guest 3			translate the phrase "house without wheels" to a language of your choice, and stomp and clap the rhythm of this new phrase	
guest 4				

0:00

41 each measure from here lasts around 30 seconds each 42 43 44

guest 1	30 sec turn off the faucet and walk slowly out of the bathroom	pace across the house before moving to the door of the room	gently knock on the door of the room as if it were lucky to do so	mutter facing away from the room. realize there is no internet. this house is not connected to anything
guest 2	30 sec rearrange a few items on the table randomly	rotate the plates as if spinning vinyls	Hum a low note, maintain it through breaths *p*	stop humming and rub your face and arms and body as if a violin
guest 3	30 sec go to the nearest source of glass	breath into the surface of the glass, and slide your finger on it	find some medicine, and gently let the pills flow inside like a rainmaker	walk towards the the bathroom
guest 4	30 sec	a		

C

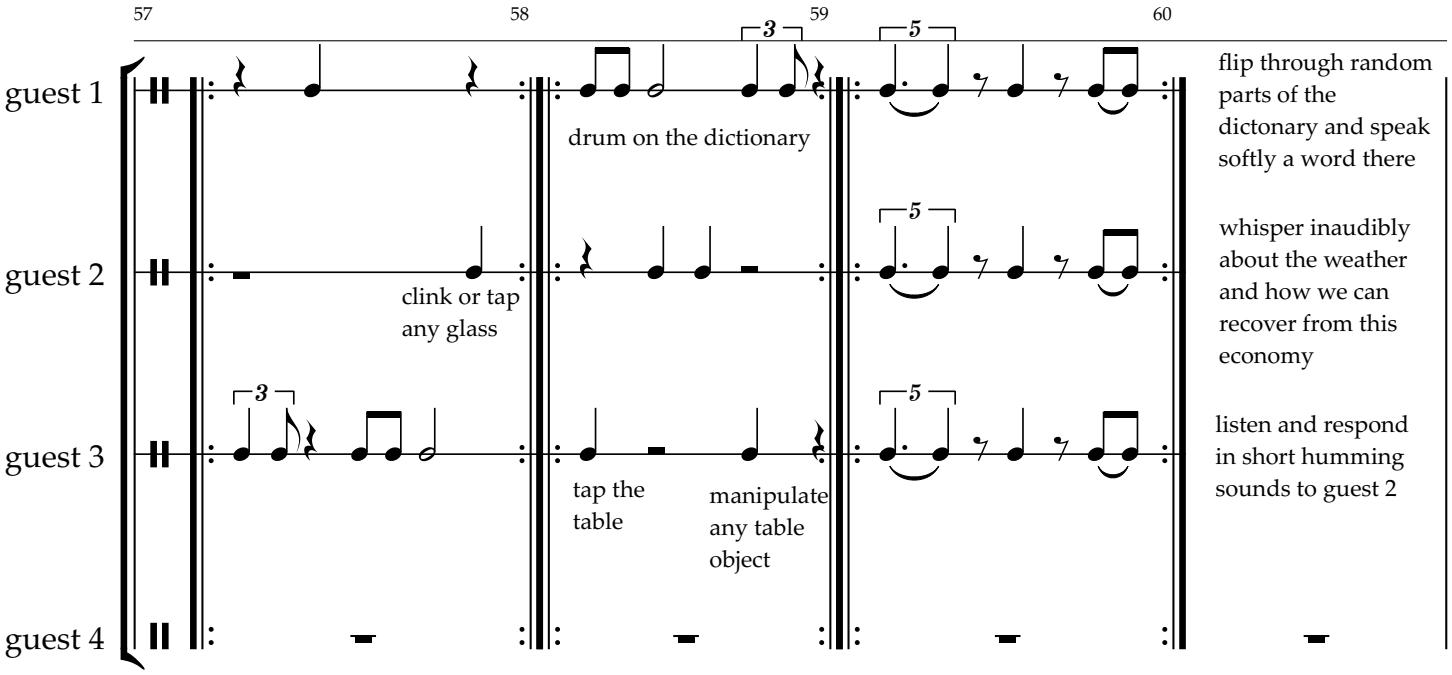
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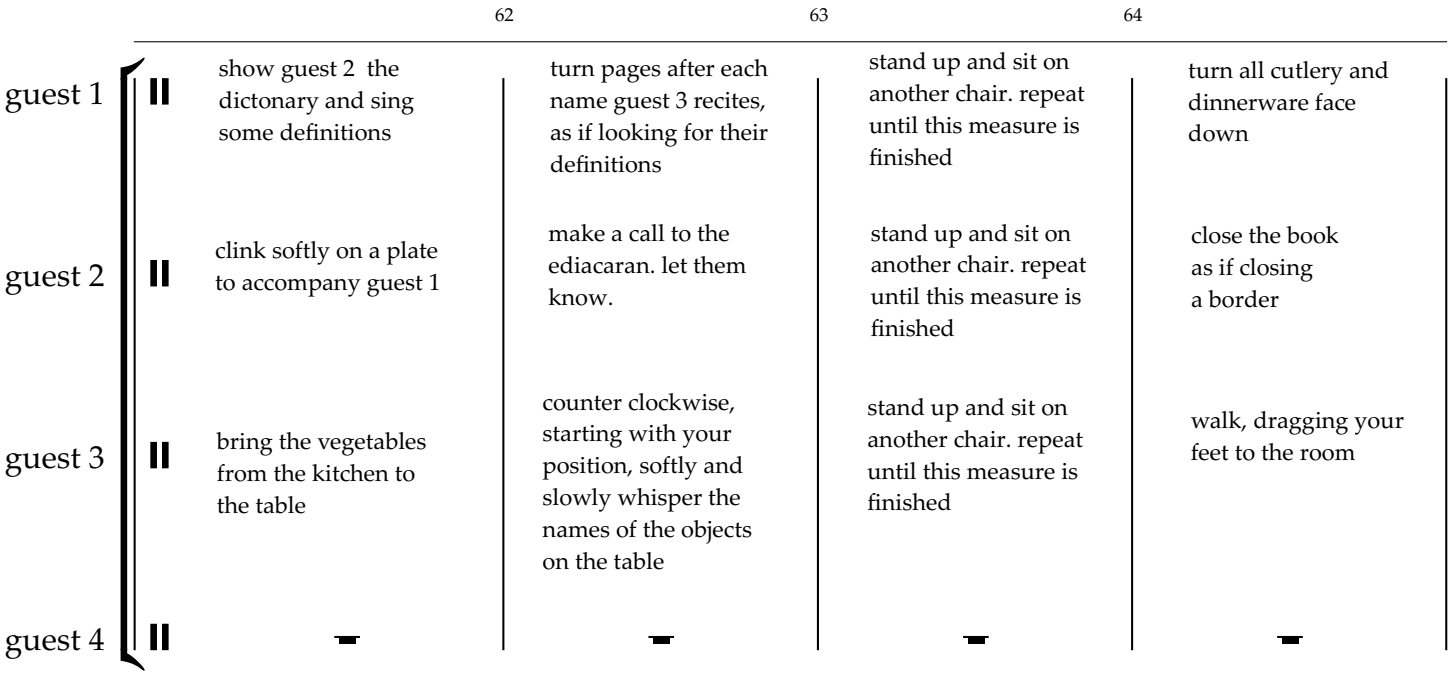
guest 1	mutter facing away from the room. realize there is no internet. this house is not connected to anything	leave the door of the room ajar and walk away	walk towards the shell	hold the shell and tap on it
guest 2	walk away from the room	walk towards the laundry	fold the clothes as loudly as you can *f*	place the folded clothes in the laundry basin filled with water *p*
guest 3	walk in circles inside the bathroom	turn on the shower	turn the shower on and off	Wash your face
guest 4				

	49	50	51	52
guest 1	Listen to the shell this sound is part of the music	pretend to whisper a story into the shell about the way clouds pass	walk towards the table and place the shell on it to act as a centerpiece	Go to the floor and pick up the dictionary
guest 2	gently lift the folded clothes from the basin letting water drip	find a place to hang the clothes and hang them	take a broom and sweep the floor	sweep in small circles as if stirring small hurricanes
guest 3	Take a toothbrush and brush your hair with it	Brush the mirror where your hair is.	Brush the walls going in small circles	leave the brush and turn the faucet on and off
guest 4	𝄻	𝄻	𝄻	𝄻

for the next four measures
repeat 2-3 times then improvise until
15 seconds have passed

	53	54	55	56
guest 1	place the dictionary on the table. this is the meal.	move the dictionary on the plate until it feels right	examine what's on the table, make adjustments for the meal	15 sec turn the pages
guest 2	leave the broom and go to the table	spill any remaining water from the glasses on the table at the sink	examine what's on the table, bring a pitcher of water	15 sec pour water into the glasses
guest 3	leave the faucet off and go to the table	prepare the table and guests for the meal	examine what's on the table, make adjustments for the meal	15 sec 3 use the table objects as percussion
guest 4	𝄻	𝄻	𝄻	𝄻

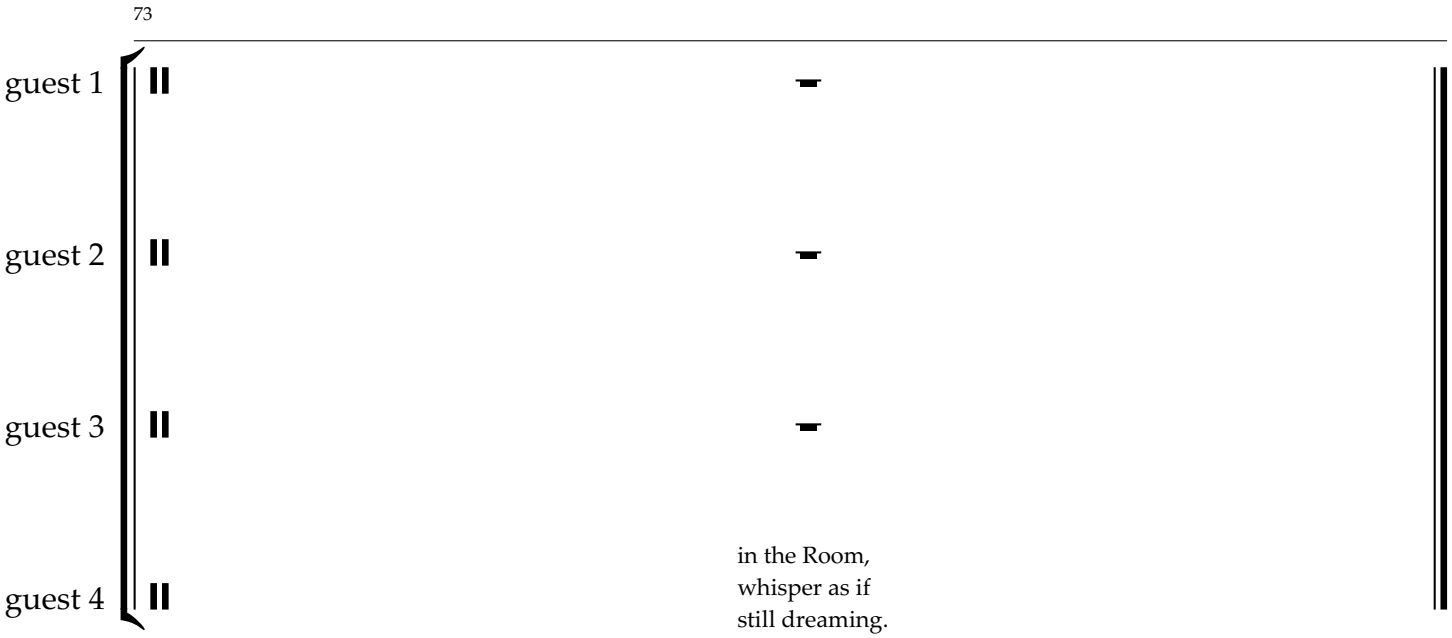

57
58
59
60
guest 1
guest 2
guest 3
guest 4
drum on the dictionary
clink or tap any glass
tap the table
manipulate any table object
flip through random parts of the dictonary and speak softly a word there
whisper inaudibly about the weather and how we can recover from this economy
listen and respond in short humming sounds to guest 2


62
63
64
guest 1
guest 2
guest 3
guest 4
show guest 2 the dictonary and sing some definitions
clink softly on a plate to accompany guest 1
bring the vegetables from the kitchen to the table
turn pages after each name guest 3 recites, as if looking for their definitions
make a call to the ediacaran. let them know.
counter clockwise, starting with your position, softly and slowly whisper the names of the objects on the table
stand up and sit on another chair. repeat until this measure is finished
stand up and sit on another chair. repeat until this measure is finished
stand up and sit on another chair. repeat until this measure is finished
turn all cutlery and dinnerware face down
close the book as if closing a border
walk, dragging your feet to the room

D

	65	66	67	68
guest 1	stand from the table and walk to the kitchen dragging yourself	fry an egg	continue to fry the egg	the egg will gradually bloom into seismograph
guest 2	sit on any chair around the table and take deep breaths	sit on any chair around the table and take deep breaths	go to the glass garden	realize it is fed by the moon.
guest 3	whimper into the room as if to something frail and ill	whimper into the room as if to something	allow the wind to gently shut the door	listen to the walls
guest 4	–	–	–	–

	69	70	71	72
guest 1	walk towards the room, and join guest 3 outside	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	–
guest 2	walk back into the house	walk towards the room, and join guest 1 and 3 by the door	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	–
guest 3	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	whisper and hum to nothing in particular	–
guest 4	–	–	–	wake up.


73
guest 1
guest 2
guest 3
guest 4
in the Room,
whisper as if
still dreaming.